

# THE REQUIREMENT ELICITATION CHECKLIST

The discovery questions that separate a stated request from the real requirement underneath it.

## WHEN SOMEONE SAYS

### "We need an export button."

The requested solution is a clue. It is rarely the requirement.

#### 1 PROBLEM BEFORE SOLUTION

The requested solution is a clue, rarely the requirement.

#### 2 CURRENT STATE FIRST

You can't design a better process without knowing today's.

#### 3 FIND THE TRIGGER

A click and an overnight file are different pieces of work.

#### 4 MAP THE HAPPY PATH

Get the simple version working on paper before hunting edge cases.

#### 5 HUNT FOR EXCEPTIONS

They don't volunteer themselves — go looking on purpose.

#### 6 SPOT RULES IN SENTENCES

"Trades above \$1M need sign-off" is a rule, not small talk.

#### 7 FIND THE DATA FIRST

A form field is the last decision, not the first.

#### 8 FIND THE DEPENDENCIES

Found in elicitation: a planning input. Found in sprint two: a delay.

#### 9 DEFINE SUCCESS MEASURABLY

If nobody can say what "better" looks like, nobody knows when to stop.

#### 10 WRITE DOWN OPEN QUESTIONS

An unanswered question you decided alone is a hidden assumption.

## BEFORE YOU WRITE THE TICKET

- ☐ Problem understood, not just the request
- ☐ Trigger identified
- ☐ Exceptions surfaced on purpose
- ☐ Data source and ownership confirmed

- ☐ Current state and workaround known
- ☐ Happy path mapped before exceptions
- ☐ Business rules made explicit
- ☐ Success measurably defined

## REMEMBER

**The requirement was never the button. It was the problem underneath it.**

Every discovery conversation reduces to a stated ask, the real problem underneath it, and the questions that connect the two.